# Relative clauses

## Understand it

A relative clause gives more information about a noun. Defining clauses identify which one we mean and have no commas. Non-defining clauses add extra information about something already clear, and are separated by commas; you cannot use that in them.

Relative clauses let you combine two short sentences into one longer, smoother one, which raises your grammar score in both writing and speaking.

## The rules

- Defining clauses give necessary information and have no commas: The woman who lives next door is a teacher.
- Non-defining clauses add extra information and use commas: My brother, who lives in Paris, is a chef.
- Who for people, which for things, that for both (only defining), whose for possession, where for places.
- Which can refer to a whole idea: Prices rose, which surprised everyone.

## All the words and forms you need

| | |
|---|---|
| **People** | who · that · whom (formal object) |
| **Things** | which · that |
| **Possession** | whose |
| **Place / time / reason** | where · when · why |
| **With prepositions (formal)** | in which · by whom · during which · to whom |
| **Whole idea** | , which ... (Prices rose, which surprised everyone.) |
| **Reduced** | the man standing there · the book written in 1990 |

## Where you use it

**Writing:** Join short sentences into one stronger sentence: Tourism, which creates jobs, also harms nature.

**Speaking:** Describe people and places: It is a place where I feel relaxed.

**Reading:** A long sentence often hides a relative clause: find who or which and what it describes.

## More examples

- People who exercise regularly live longer.
- My hometown, which is near the mountains, is very quiet.

- This is the school where my mother taught.
- Teachers whose classes are small can give more feedback.
- The year when I started university was the hardest.
- Many factories closed, which led to unemployment.

## Common mistakes

| Wrong | Right |
|---|---|
| ✗ The man which called is my uncle. | ✓ The man who called is my uncle. |
| ✗ My mother, that is a nurse, works nights. | ✓ My mother, who is a nurse, works nights. |
| ✗ The book what I read was good. | ✓ The book that I read was good. |

## Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Describe a person who has influenced you.
2. Tell me about a place where you like to relax.
3. What kind of people do you get on with?
4. Describe a book which you enjoyed.
5. Is there a time when you felt very proud?

## Writing practice

Combine these into one sentence: Tokyo is a huge city. More than 13 million people live there. It is the capital of Japan.

## Practice

1. Join with who: I know a woman. She speaks five languages.

2. Join with which: The film was long. I watched it yesterday.

3. Join with where: This is the town. I grew up there.

4. Join with whose: A man works here. His son is a doctor.

5. Correct: The teacher which taught me is retired.

6. Add a comma if needed: Tokyo which is huge is crowded.

## Answers

1. I know a woman who speaks five languages.
2. The film, which I watched yesterday, was long.
3. This is the town where I grew up.
4. A man whose son is a doctor works here.
5. The teacher who taught me is retired.
6. Tokyo, which is huge, is crowded.